
Divergent Thinking Phase:

- Distribute “Post-It” notes and pens or markers to all participants. Typically, 10-12 people works best.
- Pose the problem in terms of a “focal question.” Display it in one sentence on a large easel or whiteboard.
- Ask the group to write down responses to the question, using key words that will fit on the small “Post-It” note.
- Stick all the notes on a wall for all to see—treat all ideas the same.
- When a pause follows the initial flow of ideas, the group is reaching the end of their conventional thinking and the new divergent ideas are then likely to emerge.
- End the “collection stage” of the brainstorming after two or three pauses.

Convergent Thinking Phase:

- Ask the participants as a group to rearrange the notes on the wall according to their commonalities or similar concepts. No talking is permitted. Some notes may be moved several

times as notes begin to cluster. Copying some notes is permitted to allow ideas to be included in more than one group.

- Select a word or phrase that characterizes each grouping or cluster once all the notes have been arranged.
- Identify any notes that do not easily fit with others and consider them either useless noise or the beginning of an idea that deserves further attention.
- Assess what the group has accomplished in terms of new ideas or concepts identified or new areas that need more work or further brainstorming.
- Instruct each participant to select one or two areas that deserve the most attention. Tabulate the votes.
- Set the brainstorming group’s priorities based on the voting and decide on the next steps for analysis.